

וַיִּדְבֹּר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה בְּמִדְבַּר סִינִי בַשָּׁנָה הַשְּׁנִיָּה לְצֵאתָם מִמִּצְרָיִם מִצְרַיִם בְּחֹדֶשׁ הָרִאשׁוֹן לֵאמֹר: וַיַּעֲשׂוּ בְנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל אֶת הַפֶּסַח בְּמוֹעֶדוֹ (ט:א-ב). Hashem said: I want you to bring the פסח. What happened? There were people who couldn't bring it. The פסוק says: (ט:ו) וַיְהִי אֲנָשִׁים אֲשֶׁר הָיוּ טִמְאִים לְנֶפֶשׁ אָדָם (ט:ו). For whatever reason, their קדושה was at a level that prevented them from bringing the פסח. What did Hashem give them the opportunity to do? He gave them the mitzvah of פסח שני.

If you were to ask any one of us: What is the most profound relationship we can have with הקדוש ברוך הוא? Most of us would confidently answer: When הקדוש ברוך הוא comes down to עולם הזה to dwell among us, וּשְׁכַנְתִּי בְּתוֹכְכֶם. However, as from Yidden with a good השקפה, there is an even greater relationship than that, and that is for us to seek out הקדוש ברוך הוא, not wait for Hashem to come to us.

R' Ahron Soloveitchik זצ"ל once gave a דרשה in Kew Gardens where he alluded to this thought. There's a Gemara that the Kaiser - the Roman emperor, who was a רשע (and eventually killed רבי עקיבא) - asked רבי (רבי עקיבא) a fascinating question. "In your opinion, which are greater? הקדוש ברוך הוא's achievements or Man's?" Instead of answering immediately, רבי עקיבא said, "Give me three days to give you the answer." The Kaiser agreed. רבי עקיבא went home and told his wife to bake her finest cookies and cakes, for which she was famous. "Make them special," he said. "They're for the Caesar." Thus motivated, she outdid herself. Over the next three days, she prepared a magnificent selection of baked goods. She arranged them masterfully in a basket and רבי עקיבא began the trip back to the palace. On the way back, he stopped along the roadside and picked up some pebbles, rocks, and shmutz, and added them to one side of the basket. When he came before the Kaiser, the Kaiser asked, "Do you have the answer to my question? Which are greater, Man's achievements or הקדוש ברוך הוא's?" רבי עקיבא replied, "The answer is in the basket." He offered the basket to the ruler and said, "Try a cookie." The Kaiser ate one and said, "Delicious!" Then רבי עקיבא told him to taste a little bit of the sand and shmutz. The Kaiser took some of the sand and shmutz and spat it out. רבי עקיבא said, "You see whose achievements are greater." To which the Kaiser replied, "You are wise, רבי עקיבא. Had you answered that God's achievements are greater, I would have denounced you for doing מילה ברית on your children."

In a similar fashion, Hashem wants Man to achieve the highest level of קדושה. We can achieve a certain level by doing our מצוות, we can achieve the level where Hashem is וּשְׁכַנְתִּי בְּתוֹכְכֶם, but Hashem wants even more than that. He wants Man to come to Him. That's what happened with קרבן פסח שני. People came to משה רבינו and said נִגְרַע? We want to have an opportunity to serve Hashem. They came up and said, "We want to come to Hashem". Hashem said, "I'm going to give you another chance." Of course, everyone knows that פסח שני represents that we always get another chance. But in the realm of what I'm saying to you here, this represents Man's striving to come close to Hashem, which is an even higher מדרגה than Hashem wanting to come to us.

That's what Hashem really wants from us, to reach that מדרגה that we want to come close to Him, doing more than exactly what the תורה tells us, לַפְּנִים מִשְׁנֵי הַדִּין. We could compare this to נדב ואביהוא who also wanted to do more but they did it outside the boundaries of what is acceptable. We cannot invent our own ways of serving Hashem. But these people - whoever they were, whether they were the יוסף of נושאי ארון, or people who were טמאי מת מצוה, whatever the case may have been - did it right. They came to משה and asked, "What can we do?" Hashem said, "You know what? You deserve a מצוה; I'm going to add an extra מצוה in the תורה in your זכות. I'm going to give you פסח שני." So it was in the merit of their wanting to come close to Hashem that we see what Man's opportunities are.

